

URSULA K. LE GUIN

*The Left Hand of
Darkness*

IMPRESSIONS · READ SEPTEMBER 2026

Truth is a matter of the imagination.
The soundest fact may fail or prevail in
the style of its telling: like that singular
organic jewel of our seas, which grows
brighter as one woman wears it and, worn
by another, dulls and goes to dust. Facts
are no more solid, coherent, round and
real than pearls are. But both are sensitive

— Gently Ai

On the fickle nature of "Truth".

King in his own eyes is Kharide

— Prime Minister Estraven

To a king, or rather a madman, his country is not its people,
its culture, or its struggles. It is nothing but himself: his
pride and his power. The nation is the king's ego: every
wound to it is a wound to him, every praise of it is praise
of him. Every judgment of the nation is a judgment of the
king.

When I say patriotism. I mean fear.
The fear of the other. And its expressions are political, not poetical: hate, rivalry, aggression. It grows in us that fear. It grows in us year by year.

— Prime minister Estraven

progress is less important than presence.

To exhibit the perfect uselessness of the knowing the answer to the wrong question

— Faxe

On the planet Winter, the Handdarata is one of the two major religions, the other one being the Yomeshta. The cornerstone belief of the Handdarata is that one should strive towards ignorance, while the Yomeshta hold that all of time was seen at once by Meshe, and so all is already known, all is light. Despite the pursuit of ignorance, the Handdarata follow the mystical ritual of foretelling. The ritual has primarily the asker and the foretellers: the asker gets to ask one question, usually at a high material cost and often an even higher personal cost. It seems funny that the religion of ignorance has the ability to foretell the future so exactly. The foretellings seldom bring the solace the asker sought; rather, their lives are further worsened by knowing than by unknowing. It goes to show the value of ignorance to human existence, and the futility of chasing certainty, for a life fully known is death.

Ignorance is a ground of thought.
Unproof is the ground of action.

— Faxe

Faxe: What is known? What is
sure. predictable, inevitable-the
one certain thing you know con-
cerning your future and mine ?

Genly Ai: That we shall die.

Faxe: ... The only thing that makes life
possible is permanent, intolerable uncer-
tainty: not knowing what comes next.

Burden and privilege are shared
out equally; everybody has the
same risk to run choice to make.
Therefore nobody here is quite as
free as a free male anywhere else.

-A comment made on the androgynous society of Winter.

There is no division of humanity into strong
and weak halves, protective/protected, dom-
inant/submissive, owner/chattel, active/pas-
sive. In fact the whole the whole tendency to
dualism that pervades human thinking may be
found to be lessened or changed, on Winter.

Commentary on the androgynous society of Winter.

Hainish postulate that continuous sexual capacity and organized social aggression, neither of which are attributes of any mammal but man, are cause and effect? Or, like Tumass Song Angot, did they consider war to be a purely masculine displacement-activity, a vast Rape, and therefore in their experiment eliminate the masculinity that rapes and the femininity that is raped?

The stranger who comes unknown is a guest. Your enemy is your neighbour.

Compare the torrent and the glacier.
Both get where they are going.

He wanted his hearers to be frightened and angry. His themes were not pride and love at all, though he used the words perpetually; as he used them they meant self-praise and hate. He talked a great deal about Truth also, for he was, he said, “cutting down beneath the veneer of civilization.”

Thoughts of Estraven on a speech given by the new prime minister who was responsible for his exile.

... Of course there is no veneer, the process is one of growth, and primitiveness and civilization are degrees of the same thing. If civilization has an opposite, it is war. Of those two things, you have either one, or the other. Not both.

To oppose something is to
maintain it....To oppose vulgar-
ity is inevitably to be vulgar.

— Estraven

To be an atheist is to maintain God.
His existence or his nonexistence, it
amounts to much the same, on the plane
of proof. Thus *proof* is a word not often
used among the Handdarata, who have
chosen not to treat God as a fact, subject
either to proof or to belief: and they
have broken the circle, and go free. To
learn which questions are unanswerable,
and *not to answer them*: this skill is most
needful in times of stress and darkness.

“Curiosity, adventure.” He hesitated and smiled slightly. “The augmentation of the of the field of intelligent life”.

How does one hate a country, or love one?

“Tibe talks about it; I lack the trick of it. I know people, I know towns, farms, hills and rivers and rocks, I know how the sun at sunset in autumn falls on the side of a certain plowland in the hills; but what is the sense of giving a boundary to all that, of giving it a name and ceasing to love where the name ceases to apply?

What is love of one’s country; is it hate of one’s uncountrry? Then it’s not a good thing. Is it simply self-love? That’s a good thing, but one mustn’t make a virtue of it, or a profession. . . . Insofar as I love

life, I love the hills of the Domain of Estre, but that sort of love does not have a boundary-line of hate. And beyond that,

I am ignorant, I hope.”Ignorant, in the Handdara sense: to ignore the abstraction, to hold fast to the thing. There was in this attitude something feminine, a refusal of the abstract, the ideal, a submissiveness

to the given, which rather displeased me.Yet he added, scrupulous, “A man who doesn’t detest a bad government is a fool. And if there were such love?

That’s a good thing, but one mustn’t make a virtue of it, or a profession. . . .

Insofar as I love life, I love the hills of the

“A man who doesn’t detest a bad government is a fool. And if there were such a thing as a good government on earth, it would be a great joy to serve it.”

— Estraven

Fire and fear, good servants, bad lords.

— Estraven

*Light is the left hand of darkness
and darkness is right hand of light.
Two are one, life and death, lying
together like lovers in kemmer,
like hands joined together,
like the end and the way.*

— Tormer's Lay

Duality is an essential isn't it?...So
long as there is *myself* and *the other*

“said, “Why are my sons followed thus by darkness?” His kemmering said, “Because they were born in the house of flesh, therefore death follows at their heels. They are in the middle of time. In the beginning there was the sun and the ice, and there was no shadow. In the end when we are done, the sun will devour itself and shadow will eat light, and there will be nothing left but the ice and the darkness.”

“ Any need to explain the sources of that fear vanished with the fear; what I was left with was, at last, acceptance of him as he was. Until then I had rejected him, refused him his own reality. He had been quite right to say that he, the only person on Gethen who trusted me, was the only Gethenian I distrusted. For he was the only one who had entirely accepted me as a human being: who had liked me personally and given me entire personal loyalty: and who therefore had demanded of me an equal degree of recognition, of acceptance. I had not been willing to give it. I had been afraid to give it. I had not wanted to give my trust, my friendship to a man who was a woman, a woman who was a man.”

— Genly Ai

“A profound love between two people involves, after all, the power and chance of doing profound hurt”

— Genly Ai

“A friendship so much needed by us both in our exile, and already so well proved in the days and nights of our bitter journey, that it might as well be called, now as later, love. But it was from the difference between us, not from the affinities and likenesses, but from the difference, that that love came: and it was itself the bridge, the only bridge, across what divided us. ”

— Genly Ai

“Alone, I cannot change your world.

But I can be changed by it. Alone, I must listen, as well as speak. Alone, the relationship I finally make, if I make one, is not impersonal and not only political: it is individual, it is personal, it is both more and less than political. Not We and They; not I and It; but I and Thou. Not political, not pragmatic, but mystical. In a certain sense the Ekumen is not a body politic, but a body mystic. It considers beginnings to be extremely important. Beginnings, and means. Its doctrine is just the reverse of the doctrine that the end justifies the means. It proceeds, therefore, by subtle ways, and slow ones, and queer, risky ones; rather as evolution does, which is in certain senses its model. ... So I was sent alone, for your sake? Or for my own? I don't know. ”

— Genly Ai
